



The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory (JCRT)

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The Religious Art of Andy Warhol

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The Divine Simulacrum of Andy Warhol: Baudrillard's Light on the Pope of Pop's "Religious Art"

a review of *The Religious Art of Andy Warhol*, Jane Daggett Dillenger. (New York: Continuum, 1998); 128 pages, \$39.95.

By Benjamin Bennett-Carpenter

From explicitly religious art to art that 'is, but isn't' 'religious,' from that which lies beyond art, such as objects of veneration, to a postmodern iconography of simulacra, Andy Warhol contributes significantly to the negotiation of twentieth, and now twenty-first, century culture in America and beyond.' His influence on contemporary art, religion and culture is recognized and will continue to increase as thinkers pursue questions about image and reality, representation, originality, visual culture, identity, and sexuality, not to mention technology, spirituality, business, and God.' Of Warhol's multiple contributions, several stand out in particular.' Warhol's explicitly religious art, especially brought to light in Jane Daggett Dillenger's recent publication, *The Religious Art of Andy Warhol*, reveals a transformation of traditional religious images and themes into lively twentieth century religious art.' But beyond his explicitly religious works as highlighted by Daggett Dillenger's book, one can see that Warhol's entire *oeuvre* has 'religious' qualities, producing an art that 'is, but isn't,' religious.' Further, Warhol is significant for his part in what Jean Baudrillard calls the 'disappearance of art,' a kind of transfiguration of art into objects of veneration.' Finally, in line with Baudrillard's thought regarding the 'successive phases of the image' and the 'disappearance of God' into simulacra, Warhol produces images like that of Marilyn Monroe that no longer represent reality but offer a simulacra, a never-ending play of signs among signs stretching to infinity.

> who was at the opening with Warhol, told how this 'series appeared as an extension of the now inaccessible message of Leonardo's famous masterpiece: a sort of replay and reactualization of

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> In Marilyn, Liz, Jackie, Warhol seeks an imagery that codes a private meaning placed at the top, during ascension. [43]

The Disappearance (Transfiguration) of Art

> '[Duchamp] extracted the bottle rack from the real world', displaced it on another level to the art world, putting an end to the bottle rack as a real object, to art as the invention of another scene, a new circuit.' Extrematization of the two forms: the bottle rack, ex-inscribed from its context, from

> contemporary painting cultivates not only ugliness (which is still an aesthetic value), but

> I asked Ivan [Karp] for ideas too, and at a certain point he said, 'Why don't you paint something pastoral!' They're ridiculous!' They're blazing bright and vulgar!' I mean, he loved those con-

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> To this murderous capacity is opposed the dialectical capacity of representations as a visibil

1. It is the reflection of a basic reality.
2. It masks and perverts a basic reality.
3. It masks the _absence_ of a basic reality.
4. It bears no relation to reality whatever: it is its own pure simulacrum.[^75]

1. Does the image of Marilyn reflect a real Marilyn?
2. Does the image of Marilyn mask and pervert a real Marilyn?
3. Does the image of Marilyn mask the *absence* of a real Marilyn?
4. Does the image of Marilyn bear no relation to a real Marilyn at all?' 'Is it its own pure simulacrum?'
3. Warhol's 'original' silkscreen image of Marilyn
4. The cropped publicity photograph of Marilyn used by Warhol
5. Marilyn 'herself' at the photo shoot

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Notes

She also notes that the day after Warhol's death, a Swiss art journal which was supposed to receive some prints based on typical Swiss images like cuckoo clocks, the Matterhorn, and Toblerone chocolates instead received a 'package from the Factory [that] contained a photo edition of 120 numbered and signed copies of four stitched-together photographs of skeletons!' "" Later, after his discussion of Robert Mapplethorpe, Giles writes, 'Holding that the religious significance of any given work is more important than what its creator happened to believe' what, after all did Leonardo or Raphael 'believe'? 'the Roman church has never been shy about requisitioning artist's work for its own ideological uses.' The Collection of Modern Religious Art in the Vatican Museums currently boasts the unorthodox paintings by John Sloan (*Indian Religious Dance*), Graham Sutherland, and Francis Bacon, as well as ceramics by Picasso.' One wonders how long it will be before Warhol and Mapplethorpe find their way into this elevated company,' 294-295. * * *

Benjamin Bennett-Carpenter, most recently a doctoral student in Religion and Culture at Catholic University of America, received an MA in Religious Studies from the University of Denver in 1999. Paper presentations have included 'Questions of the Divine and Demonic, Neurosis and Creativity in Teresa of Avila's *Life*' and 'Worlds Colliding: Images of Ganesa.' Interests include semiotics, rhetoric, visual culture, and performance art.

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